The Care Leaders
Learning

Keynote workbook and resource

Living a Careless Life

Understanding the lived experiences of children in care

Luke Rodgers BEM

This workbook belongs to

Date started



How to use this resource

Part workbook, part reference. Use it in the keynote, then keep it close: in your bag, in supervision, at your support group. Come back to it whenever a young person puzzles you.

In the room
During the keynote. A few minutes each.

On your own
At home or at your desk, in the weeks after.

With your team
Supervision, team meetings, support groups.

Every activity follows the same path

Why
What it is for

What good looks like
Read the example

Your turn
Write about your young person

Done when
How you know

Back to practice
What you will do

Two more labels you will see

Learn
The theory. Read it once, then come back to it.

Tool to keep
Pages to photocopy, cut out or pin up.

Look after yourself. Some of this may bring up your own experiences. Take a break when you need one, and take anything heavy to supervision or someone you trust.

Choose your young person

Think of one young person you are trying to support right now. Carry them through this resource. Use a made-up name and leave out anything that could identify them.

Made-up name

Age

How I know them, and why I chose them





Luke Rodgers BEM

Founder and CEO, The Care Leaders

From care leaver to care leader.

Your facilitator

Luke went into care at 10. By 15 he was living in B&B accommodation, and by 18 in a caravan. He brings that lived experience together with years of professional experience leading change in children's services.

He founded The Care Leaders, a consultancy delivering transformation, training and leadership across children's social care, working with local authorities across England. He also founded the Care Leavers National Movement and has led engagement on the national rewrite of the Fostering Services National Minimum Standards.

Luke is a keynote speaker at conferences and events across the UK. He was a Knowledge Equity Fellow at Saïd Business School, University of Oxford, and sat on the advisory board of the Rees Centre at the University of Oxford.

BEM

British Empire Medal, 2018 Birthday Honours, for commitment to children and families.

Gold

Dual Perspective Leadership Award, iESE Public Sector Transformation Awards 2026.

Winner

Workforce Development Award, Children & Young People Now Awards 2023.

Follow me on LinkedIn

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What you will learn, and where you are starting

Four goals for the keynote. Rate yourself now, then again at the end.



By the end you will be able to

1. **Understand** the impact of the language we use about children with a social worker.
2. **Explain** how attachment and trauma shape the nervous system.
3. **See** how school and children's social care clash, and who pays for it.
4. **Use** four practical tools to support young people.

Before you start: rate each statement

I understand how the words we use about young people shape what happens to them.	1 2 3 4 5
I can explain how attachment and trauma affect the nervous system.	1 2 3 4 5
I can see where school and children's social care clash for a young person.	1 2 3 4 5
I have practical tools I can use with a young person this week.	1 2 3 4 5
I feel confident to act differently with the young person I have in mind.	1 2 3 4 5

1 strongly disagree · 5 strongly agree

What's inside

Four parts. Story to notice, Theory to understand, Action to practise, Keep for the tools you will come back to.



Story

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In the room

Start here: the lighter

A composite story. It draws on real experiences but is not one person. Read it, then answer as honestly as you can.

Jay, 14

It's period four on a Wednesday and Jay's science class is lighting Bunsen burners for the first time. Jay has been in his foster home for six weeks and this is his third school in two years. He mostly keeps his head down.

Nobody can find the striker. While the group waits, Jay takes a lighter out of his blazer pocket and lights their burner. A couple of the others laugh.

Mr Hughes sees it from across the room. He goes red and points at the door. "Out. Now."

Ten minutes later he comes out, still angry. "Give me that. Where on earth did you get a lighter from?"

Jay looks at the floor. "It's my mum's," he says. Then, quietly, "I don't live with her any more. I'm in care."

Mr Hughes stops. Nobody had told him. His face changes completely. He hands the lighter back. "Just keep it in your bag, OK?"

The lighter wasn't his mum's. Jay got it from a friend.



You are Mr Hughes. Jay has just told you he is in care. What do you say next?

What happened to your anger when you read his answer?

What would you do with the lighter?

Keep your answers. We come back to Jay on page 27.

1 Story

Meet Sam. First you will read what is written about Sam. Then you will read Sam's story.



In this part

We inherit words	**8**
Sam's profile, and two scores	**9**
Sam's story, and the same two scores	**10**

In the room

We inherit words



What words do we use to describe children with a social worker? Somewhere, without meaning to, we store them. Then they start to do our thinking for us.

Challenging	High risk	Vulnerable	LAC and CIN	Damaged
"They are going to display challenging behaviour."	"They are dangerous to be around."	"They cannot look after themselves."	"They are lacking and in need."	"They are broken."

The bigger problem: the expectation shapes what we do

They are broken → **They are unfixable** → **I don't have the skills** → **I can't help**

Which of these words have you heard, or used, this month?

Which "I can't help" thought is most familiar to you?

In the room

Meet Sam

16 years old

Everyone writes about Sam. A profile is a statutory document. It can go by different names, and it often arrives long before the young person does.



Sam's profile

Is at high risk of absconding.	Persistent young offender with offences including burglary and affray.
Known to deal and has been caught with drugs at school.	Has stolen previous foster carer's car in the night.
Low attendance at school and is disengaged with other pupils.	Has issues with attachment.
Isolates themselves in their room. We are seeking psychological assessments as we think it links to early childhood trauma.	Disruptive behaviour when confronted with authority, and their "outbursts" are hard to control.
Struggles to follow simple house rules when living in a foster placement.	Hard to build a rapport as can be guarded and "closed".

Pause. On your own, score these from 1 (low) to 10 (high). Hold your answers.

How confident would you be offering Sam a place in your school, home or service?	/10
How concerned would you be about Sam?	/10

In the room

Sam's profile, and Sam's story



The same events, read twice. On the left is what was written. On the right is what was actually happening.

What was written	What was happening
High risk of absconding	Was late home.
Burglary and affray	Took their own things from their parents' house without asking. Sam was attacked for it.
Known to deal	Smoked some weed with friends at school.
Stole a foster carer's car	Frightened and lonely, drove to see their mum. This happened once.
Low attendance, disengaged	Always being moved school. Just wants friends.
Issues with attachment	Struggles to feel safe with people.
Isolates in their room	When reminded of an abusive family, goes to their room and is often found crying.
"Outbursts" with authority	Lived where abuse was normal. Gets scared when they hear shouting.
Struggles with house rules	Has lived in so many places the rules keep changing.

Sam just wants to be loved.

Score again. Compare with page 9.

How confident would you be offering Sam a place in your school, home or service? /10

How concerned would you be about Sam? /10

What did you feel first when you read the profile?

"I can't help" becomes "I want to help."

What changes when the language changes

Did your scores move? What moved them?

2

Theory

Why the words stick, what Sam's brain learned to expect, and how two systems clash.



In this part

Five biases in the file	**13**
Attachment and the brain	**15**
Two timetables	**18**
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Learn

Five biases hiding in the file



Unconscious bias is the associations we hold, outside our conscious awareness and control. These five showed up in Sam's profile. They show up in every file.

1
Age
Treating who they were at one age as who they are now.

Ask yourself
What has changed since this was written?

2
Gender
Boys read as risky, girls as vulnerable.

Ask yourself
Would I write it the same way about a girl, or a boy?

3
Anchor
The first thing you read frames everything after it.

Ask yourself
Did I meet them before I read about them?

4
Horns effect
One bad trait colours the whole picture.

Ask yourself
What are they good at?

5
Confirmation
New information gets fitted to the old story.

Ask yourself
What would prove me wrong?

Redundancy
We don't feel we have the skills to help.

Judgement
We wrongly judge young people.

Rejection
Young people are rejected.

Which bias do you catch in yourself most?

Theory

On your own | With your team

Rewrite a profile



So the first thing anyone reads about a young person makes them want to say yes. Honest about what they need, and just as clear about who they are.

Written about Sam

Persistent young offender. Known to deal. Has stolen previous foster carer's car. Disruptive when confronted with authority. Hard to build a rapport.

What good looks like

Sam is 16 and loyal to their friends. Sam has moved home and school many times and wants to stay put. Sam gets scared when adults shout, and settles with time alone, then a calm adult who checks in. Once, frightened and lonely, Sam drove to see their mum. Sam wants friends, and to be loved.

Three checks for any profile

1. Would they recognise themselves in it?
2. Does it say what helps, not only what goes wrong?
3. Would you be happy for them to read it at 18?

Your turn: your young person, in their best light and honestly

Who they are

What they are good at

What has happened to them

What helps on a hard day

Done when. Every box is filled and all three checks are a yes.

Back to practice. Next time you write or speak about them, start with who they are.

Learn

What Sam learned before 10



Sam's early years were shaped by three adults. A quick look at child development shows what that taught Sam. Also known as attachment theory.

Mum
Non-nurturing

Dad
Neglectful and absent

Step-dad
Strict and abusive



0 to 4 years

Relationships with parents · first attachment style · wanting their attention · developing trust · the roles of mum and dad

"My parents don't love me. They are always fighting and when I cry no one comforts me."

"I can't trust my parents. They don't keep me safe."

"My dad hits my mum, and my mum doesn't seem to care about me."

5 to 10 years

Developing logic · copying adults · ideas of male and female roles · learning good and bad · relationships with peers

"My parents shout at each other, so I should shout too."

"Dad and step-dad are violent. That's what it means to be a man."

"Shouting and hitting are good. It's what my parents do."

"I will have relationships like the ones I have with my parents."

What might your young person have learned about adults before they met you?

Theory

Learn

The brain has two principles



It looks for patterns, and it is built to survive. For Sam, the threat might not be a snarling dog. It might be a relationship.

1 Pattern seeking

The brain sorts the world into familiar and unfamiliar. When we try to comfort Sam, the brain may read it as a threat, because relationships in the past were threatening. We call this a red flag.

Adults: logical, regulated	Children: emotive, unregulated
Call a friend	Become triggered
Communicate boundaries	Push people away
Sit with the emotion	Panic

2 Survival orientated

When we are scared, the brain goes into survival mode. Walter Cannon described fight or flight in 1915. We now talk about five responses.



Freeze, flop and fawn were added later. Pete Walker named the fawn response.

"Connections on the outside build connections on the inside." Dr Becky Bailey

Learn | On your own

What you see, and what it might be



These responses are not choices. They are a body trying to stay safe. Knowing which one you are seeing helps you respond to the fear, not just the behaviour.

Response	What you might see	What it might be	What can help
Fight	Shouting, arguing, lashing out.	Fear, dressed as anger.	Calm first. Lower your voice. Talk later.
Flight	Walking out, running off, staying out.	Leaving before being let down.	Don't chase into conflict. Say where you will be.
Freeze	Going quiet or blank.	Overwhelmed, can't find words.	Stop the questions. Sit alongside.
Flop	"Whatever", shutting down, sleeping.	Armour against rejection.	Don't read it as disrespect. Stay warm.
Fawn	Pleasing, agreeing, "I'm fine".	Keeping adults happy to stay safe.	Notice the "fine". Make it safe to say no.

"Might" matters. These are guesses to test, not a diagnosis, and they never cancel out a consequence.

Your turn: decode one behaviour

What I see

What it might be

What I will try

Learn

Two timetables



Sam lives on two timetables at once: school's and children's social care's. Only the headteacher and the designated teacher know Sam is in care. When the two clash, Sam pays.

Sam's school week, as school sees it

Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Maths Late	Art	**PE No PE kit**	Geography	French
English	Drama	ICT	**Science Missed lesson**	DT
Science	Maths	English	RE	**Music Detention**

What social care was doing

Missed lesson	Seeing their social worker, or in a review meeting. School thinks absconding.
No PE kit	Lost in an emergency move to a new foster home.
Late Monday	Trying to call a social worker who starts at 9, after school starts.
Detention	For homework not done, the night of a family visit.

Two common approaches. Mark your natural position.

Behaviourist · Mrs Trunchbull — **Peter Pan · Nurturist**

Sanction and reward, routine, discipline

Behaviour is communication, compassion, relationships

Sam says: "I don't want anyone to know I am in care." Why might that be?

Theory

On your own | With your team

Your two timetables planner

Map one week for your young person: school above, social care below. Visits, reviews, family time, therapy, PEP meetings. Then circle the clashes.



Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Weekend
School	School	School	School	School	School
Social care	Social care	Social care	Social care	Social care	Social care

Where do the two timetables clash?

Who needs to know, and who will tell them?

Who's who. Designated teacher: every school has one for children in care. Virtual school head: champions their education. Supervising social worker: supports carers. Independent reviewing officer: chairs reviews. PEP: the personal education plan.

Learn

What the evidence does and does not show



Ideas from this keynote, and how firmly they stand. Use them as lenses, not labels.

Strong

Early relationships matter

The idea that early care shapes how children trust adults is well established, from Bowlby onwards.

Use with care

Attachment labels

Calling a child "attachment disordered" from their behaviour is not reliable. Only a qualified professional can assess that.

Strong

Fight or flight

Described by Cannon in 1915 and well supported since. Freeze is also widely recognised.

Emerging

Flop and fawn

Newer clinical descriptions. Useful language, with less research behind them.

Mixed

Bias training

Unconscious bias is real, but short training on its own rarely changes behaviour for long. The habits, like meeting before reading, matter more.

Practice framework

The four tools

Developed by The Care Leaders from widely used approaches. Evidence-informed, not tested in a trial.

Which idea will you hold more loosely now?

Which idea do you want to read more about?

3 Action

Four tools you can use this week. Then back to Jay.



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On your own | With your team

Tool 1: Just say yes

If we agree the words in Sam's profile are wrong, changing how we record is not enough. Sam is being turned away today. So until the words change, we ignore them.



1

Ignore what is written

Meet the young person, not the file.

2

End the cycle of rejection

Every no confirms what they already believe.

3

Just say yes

To the place, the school, the home.

Before you say no, ask yourself

- [ ] Have I met them, or only read about them?
- [ ] Which of the five biases might be doing my thinking?
- [ ] Do I know their story, or only their profile?
- [ ] What would need to be true for me to say yes?
- [ ] If I say no, who will say yes?

Your turn: a time you, or your service, said no. What would saying yes have taken?

Done when. You can name what a yes would have needed.

Back to practice. Next time a referral lands, meet before you decide.

Learn

Tool 2: Spot, Soothe, Shift



Being a safe adult, to help young people learn to trust. Spot and Soothe always come first. Then stop and decide which way to go.

They share something painful

1 Spot
Notice and name the feeling. Let them finish.

"It makes sense you feel this way."

2 Soothe
Slow down. Leave silences. Not "At least..."

"I'm here. We can talk now, or later."

1. Could they, or another child, be at risk of harm?

Yes, or not sure

No

2. Are they calm, heard and ready to hear a strength?

Not yet, or a loss

Yes

Signpost
Never reframe a disclosure. Be honest you can't keep it secret. Tell your safeguarding lead straight away.

Stay with Soothe
The default. Grief, loss and unfairness are real. "That's really unfair. I'm sorry."

Shift
Ask first, name one real strength, pause. "Can I tell you something I've noticed about you?" Pushed back? Go back to Spot.

Developed by The Care Leaders. First called Recognise, Reassure, Redefine. A practice framework: evidence-informed, not trial-tested.

On your own | With your team

Practise Spot, Soothe, Shift

Three composite moments. Write what you spot, how you would soothe, and which way you would go next.



What good looks like. Kai, 12, after a cancelled family visit: "Nobody ever turns up for me." **Spot:** "You were really looking forward to seeing her." **Soothe:** "I'm sorry. I'm here." **Then:** it's a loss, so stay with Soothe today. Shift another day.

Mia, 13
after family time

"She doesn't even care about me."

What I spot

How I soothe

Signpost, stay, or shift?

Tyler, 15
at school

"There's no point. I'll be moved again anyway."

What I spot

How I soothe

Signpost, stay, or shift?

Ash, 11
at bedtime

"You'll get rid of me like the others did."

What I spot

How I soothe

Signpost, stay, or shift?

On your own

Tool 3: Challenging stigma



When a young person says they don't want people to know they have a social worker, it is usually because they expect to be judged. If we don't challenge that, we quietly agree they will be. Five steps.

1

Tell them they will not be judged

And if they ever feel they are, they come to you.

2

Explore both scenarios

What it looks like if teachers do know, and if they don't.

3

Involve them in the decision

Agree together what to say to teachers.

4

Don't take their first answer

Ask them to think about it for a couple of days.

5

Tell them you have their back

Whatever they decide.

Try saying

"Lots of young people feel like that. Can we think about what it would look like if your teachers knew, and if they didn't? You don't have to decide today."

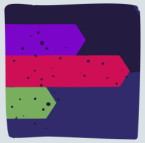
Who knows about your young person's care now?

Which step would you find hardest, and why?

Learn

Tool 4: Separating Reason from Behaviour

Holding young people accountable in a way that gives them ownership to change. Respond to the reason first, then the behaviour. Both matter. Adapted from emotion coaching.



Above the line: the behaviour, what you see

Later, calm and in private

The behaviour

Shouting, walking out, refusing. You see it first. You don't respond to it first.

3 Highlight the behaviour

"Feeling this way is OK. Behaving that way isn't."

4 Give ownership

"What can we do differently next time?"

Below the line: the reason, what you can't see

In the moment

1 Recognise the reason

"I can see something's not right for you today."

2 Offer support

"You don't have to talk now. I'll check in later."

What might be under the line

Tired, hungry, embarrassed, worried about home, struggling with a friend. You may never know. The stages still work.



Safety concern? Stop at stage 2. Follow your safeguarding procedures and speak to your safeguarding lead straight away.

Avoid three things

- Personalising the system
- Excusing behaviour
- Worrying you'll get it wrong

Think of a behaviour that alarmed you. What might have been under the line?

Which of the three things to avoid catches you out most?

In the room

Back to Jay



When a young person says something personal that stops you in your tracks, your anger drops and the behaviour slips past. This is called alarm and disarm. Here is how Mr Hughes could have used Tool 4.

What good looks like

1 Recognise the reason

"Thanks for telling me. I wasn't aware."

2 Offer support

"I want you to know you can talk to me about this, or to our designated teacher. We want to make sure you have support."

3 Highlight the behaviour

"Lighters still aren't allowed in school."

4 Give ownership

"I'll keep it in my drawer. Come and see me at the end of the day and you can have it back, and we'll agree it stays at home."

What changed? Mr Hughes still holds the line on the lighter. Jay feels heard first, so he can hear the boundary. Nothing personal, no shame.

Your turn: look back at what you wrote on page 6. What would you change now?

Has a young person ever alarmed and disarmed you? What happened?

With your team | On your own

Practise Tool 4

We are taught to deal with behaviour in two common ways: the behaviourist and the nurturer. Both can go wrong. Rewrite each one with the four stages.

Escalation nation

Event: Timmy is late for school.

Miss Trunchbull: "Why are you late?"

Timmy: "I don't know, miss."

Miss Trunchbull: "How can you not know? Detention."

Timmy: "Whatever. Chill out."

Rewrite it with the four stages

1.

2.

3.

4.

The "fine" line

Event: Dave forgets his homework.

Peter: "You didn't do your homework. Are you OK?"

Dave: "I'm fine."

Peter: "You don't seem fine. You can speak to me."

Dave: "I'm fine!" Peter: "OK, sorry."

Rewrite it with the four stages

1.

2.

3.

4.

On a hard day, are you more Trunchbull or Peter?



4

Keep

The tools and pages to come back to: in supervision, with your team, and whenever a young person puzzles you.



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Tool to keep | With your team

Words that work



Much of the language in care was written for systems, not young people. They hear it, and later they read it in their files. Ask the young person which words they prefer. Their answer wins.

Instead of		Try
~~Placement~~	»	Home
~~Contact~~	»	Family time
~~LAC~~	»	Their name, or "a child in care"
~~Absconded~~	»	Left without telling us
~~Refused to engage~~	»	Didn't want to talk yet
~~Kicked off~~	»	Was overwhelmed
~~Attention seeking~~	»	Connection seeking
~~Respite~~	»	A sleepover, a short break
~~Placement breakdown~~	»	The move, or "it ended"
~~LAC review~~	»	My meeting
~~Challenging~~	»	Needs the most support

The one word I will stop using from today

Words my young person prefers

Add your own swaps

Inspired by sector work on care language, including TACT's Language that Cares (2019).

On your own

What builds trust



For many young people in care, adults removed them, moved them and decided their lives in meetings they weren't in. Distrust is based on evidence. Trust comes back through predictability, not persuasion.

Rate yourself with your young person: 1 rarely, 5 always

1	I do what I said, when I said I would.	1 2 3 4 5
2	I explain decisions before they land.	1 2 3 4 5
3	I tell them what I am writing or saying about them.	1 2 3 4 5
4	I repair after a hard conversation.	1 2 3 4 5
5	I keep the same face, time and place where I can.	1 2 3 4 5



My lowest score, and why

One thing I will do to move it up by one

Done when. You have one specific thing to do, with a date.

Back to practice. Rate yourself again in a month.

On your own

After: where you are now, and your Monday plan



Rate the same five statements again, then make one plan.

I understand how the words we use about young people shape what happens to them.	1 2 3 4 5
I can explain how attachment and trauma affect the nervous system.	1 2 3 4 5
I can see where school and children's social care clash for a young person.	1 2 3 4 5
I have practical tools I can use with a young person this week.	1 2 3 4 5
I feel confident to act differently with the young person I have in mind.	1 2 3 4 5

1 strongly disagree · 5 strongly agree

What has changed, and why?

My Monday plan

One thing I will do

With whom

By when

How I will know it worked

1 The words written about a young person shape whether anyone says yes to them.

2 Behaviour that looks like defiance is often a survival response to past relationships.

3 A safe adult can hold a boundary and still keep the young person close.

Tool to keep

Quick reference cards

Cut along the dashes. Keep one on the fridge, one in your bag, one in your diary.



1 · Just say yes

Ignore what is written until it is right.

End the cycle of rejection.

Meet them before you decide.

2 · Spot, Soothe, Shift

Spot the feeling. **Soothe:** "I'm here."

Signpost any disclosure. **Stay** with a loss. **Shift** only when ready.

3 · Challenging stigma

1 They won't be judged. 2 Explore both scenarios. 3 Decide together. 4 Don't take the first answer. 5 Have their back.

4 · Reason and behaviour

Now: 1 recognise the reason, 2 offer support.

Later: 3 highlight the behaviour, 4 give ownership.

Five biases

Age · Gender · Anchor · Horns · Confirmation.

Ask: what would prove me wrong?

Five survival responses

Fight · Flight · Freeze · Flop · Fawn.

Respond to the fear, not just the behaviour.

On your own

Come back to this

Learning sticks when you return to it. Put three reminders in your diary now.



One week

Date

Did you do your Monday plan? What did your young person notice?

One month

Date

Which tool have you used most? Rate yourself on trust again.

Three months

Date

Watch the recording again. What do you hear now that you missed?

With your team

Run it with your team



Any page marked With your team works in supervision, a team meeting or a foster carer support group. The method is the same every time.

1
Choose one page
Twenty minutes is enough.

2
Write in silence
Everyone does Your turn on their own.

3
Share one line each
No discussion yet.

4
Agree one change
Write it in the plan below.

5
Check it next time
Ask about it at the next meeting.

Session	Page	Our change	Who checks
1	We inherit words, and Words that work		
2	Rewrite a profile		
3	Practise Spot, Soothe, Shift		
4	Practise Tool 4		

Learn

Where the ideas come from



If you want to go deeper, these are the sources behind the theory in this keynote.

Bowlby, J. (1969) *Attachment and Loss, Volume 1: Attachment.*
Where attachment theory began.

Cannon, W. B. (1915) *Bodily Changes in Pain, Hunger, Fear and Rage.*
The first description of fight or flight.

Walker, P. (2013) *Complex PTSD: From Surviving to Thriving.*
Names the fawn response.

Bailey, B. *Conscious Discipline.*
"Connections on the outside build connections on the inside."

Gottman, J. (1997) *Raising an Emotionally Intelligent Child.*
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Behaviour often signals a need, or a skill not yet learned.

Forscher, P. and others (2019) *A meta-analysis of procedures to change implicit measures. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology.*
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TACT (2019) *Language that Cares.*
Changing the language of care, with children in care.

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